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About Loyalty

‘Have you got a problem with me?’

I’ve never felt a disappointment like it. I really believed we were going to win the 2002 World Cup in Japan. I don’t know what had made me so sure. Being captain? My foot healing in time? The little coincidences, like being allocated seat number 7 on flights, just by chance? It had definitely felt like they were the right omens pointing towards this being England’s time. What I do know is that being knocked out when we were—and how we were—left me with a real hangover into the new season back home. Victoria and I went away for a week soon after the England squad got back to the UK, but even that did nothing to brighten my mood. In fact, by the end of the week, Victoria had had about enough:

‘I don’t know how much more of that I could have taken’, she said, ‘being with someone who didn’t smile or show any emotion from one day to the next, who could hardly bring himself to say two words to me or to anyone else’.

She didn’t need to tell me it was unfair on her. In the past I’d always tried to make sure that I didn’t take work home with me, didn’t get moody with my family when things weren’t going well for me, for whatever reason, at United. But this was different. And when it came time to start pre-season training, I was still feeling the same, like I hadn’t had a break at all: tired, heavy legs, no spark. It was all wrong. My job isn’t a job at all. It’s not nine to five, is it? It’s not going down a mine or driving a truck all day long. Playing soccer, training, is what I love doing and I knew I shouldn’t have been feeling like I did: as if I didn’t really want to be there, back at United already and with a new season about to get underway.